Welcome to the LVNA

Villager

The Newsletter of the Lakewood Village Neighborhood Association

February 2011 Volume 55 Number 2 Sunnyvale, California Editor: Phyllis Fowler



Monthly Meeting February 9th

At 7:00 pm in the Lakewood Park Building

Volunteer Appreciation Night!

President's Column

-Fred Fowler

A New Beginning for the LVNA



Hello once again. I'm writing to you for the 2nd to the last time as President of the Lakewood Village Neighborhood Association. I've already served more than a year since I was elected LVNA President in November, 2009. By the time the March elections happen I will have spent 15 months in the job. Those months have been good ones and I'm glad I chose to go through this all over again. I was President of the LVNA for two years in the 1990's, and that plus my current term are more than enough for me.

The fact that I'm leaving poses a question for the association. Who will follow me? Who will be the next President of the LVNA? I don't know. Probably there are only a very few people who know. Perhaps there is only one person who knows – the person who will step up next month to take the job. Perhaps even that person doesn't know at this point.

I'm writing this article and publishing it in this newsletter, and I know that it will be read by everyone in Lakewood Village. I'm not writing it FOR everyone in Lakewood Village, though. I'm writing it for just one person. You! I'm writing this to the person who will step up to the challenge and choose to follow me.

WHAT DOES IT TAKE TO BE PRESIDENT?

The post of LVNA President is just one of five elected positions within the organization. According to our bylaws, the association is governed by a board of directors consisting of a President, a 1st Vice President, *(Continued on page 4)*

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INSIDE THIS ISSUE:

LVNA All Stars!	2
Salmon Recipe	6
Origin of Valentine's Day	6
Traffic Fines Go Up!	8
Community Page	8

February Meeting: Thank You Volunteers!

By Fred Fowler



Greetings neighbors. The LVNA year is drawing to a close, and we have much to look back on with pride. 2010 was a good year for the LVNA and for the Lakewood Village neighborhood as a whole. We had a very successful Dumpster Day, a great picnic, another fine parade and a spectacular holiday lighting exhibition/contest. We had a great series of monthly meetings (including a presentation by PG&E that occurred in a blacked-out park building) and we've published another complete set of monthly newsletters. Not everything went according to plan (as if everything ever goes according to plan), but the LVNA has had a strong and successful year, and our neighborhood is all the better because of it. *(Continued on page 2)*

Hanging Shoes Follow Up

by Fred Fowler



Hello neighbors. As you recall, last month I wrote an article about a pair of tennis shoes that were hanging from a utility wire near the intersection of Lawrence Expressway and Lakehaven Drive. As I explained, they were a kind of sign that said "Drugs for sale nearby". I told you I was going to find a way to get them down, and I asked for your help to do so. I also asked you to let me know if anyone knew of other pairs shoes that were "hanging around" our neighborhood.

It didn't take long for you to respond! The newsletters were distributed on a Saturday early in January and on the next morning I got a call. It was from a neighbor of ours named "Mike". He said he was very tired of looking at those shoes and offered to help me get them down. He said he had a van with a ladder up to its roof, and he had a long tree pruning pole with a hook at (*Continued on page 3*)

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February Meeting: Thank You Volunteers!

(Continued from page 1)



The LVNA is strong because of the people who live in Lakewood Village. We all have busy lives but we have a sense of community here that is the envy of other parts of town. Most of us participate by reading the newsletter and staying informed, but there are quite a few of us who do more than that. The lifeblood of the LVNA is the volunteers who give their time to keep things running smoothly. They are the ones who publish and distribute *The Villager*, the ones who watch the dumpsters on Dumpster Day, who cook food and serve it at the picnic, and the ones who help get our parade "ducks" in line.

The LVNA is strong because of the people who live in Lakewood Village.

How many of them are there? Other neighborhood organizations in Sunnyvale are happy to have 10-12 regular participants. We have over 60 active volunteers! That's right; the list of people who have worked on at least one of the major LVNA activities this year is six times longer than almost any other neighborhood association in Sunnyvale. That's something for us all to be proud of.

Come to the Lakewood Park Building at 7:00pm on Wednesday, February 9th, to help us thank all of those volunteers. The February meeting will be our "Volunteer Recognition" party, where we'll celebrate the work of those people and give them some of the recognition they are due. State Assemblyman Paul Fong, who represents us in the California State Assembly has committed to give each and every volunteer on our list a special certificate of appreciation. There may be other tokens of appreciation from some other highly placed dignitaries as well. We'll have some light refreshments, and if you feel motivated to do so it would be great if you brought some cake/cookies, etc., to share.

It should be a great evening! I'll see you there. ◆

The LVNA All Star Volunteers

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Judy Fernandez Pat Fletcher Fred Fowler
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Hanging Shoes

(Continued from page 1)

the end of it. He would climb up on the van's roof and hook the shoes if I would direct traffic around his van while it was stopped in the street. We agreed to meet at 4:00pm that afternoon.

Just to be on the safe side I called the Sunnyvale Department of Public Safety to let them know what was going on. I explained that my neighbor and I were going to be blocking one lane of traffic on Lakehaven for a little while as we pulled the shoes down from the utility wire. The Public Safety dispatcher I spoke to told me that what Mike and I were about to do was dangerous and "strongly urged" us not to do it. She said she would pass on the information to the Lieutenant supervising the shift so that they would be aware of the activity.



At 4:00pm Mike and I met, and after the VTA #55 bus passed by we got to work. I was wearing an orange "emergency vest" I've had for many years, and Mike provided a pair of orange traffic cones. We set out the cones, parked the van, and then Mike climbed up and got the shoes down. It was all over in less than 2 minutes.

When I think about how long those shoes have been there and how little time and effort it took to get them down, I'm amazed that it wasn't done sooner. A little more than a year ago I pointed out the shoes to a high ranking member of the City of Sunnyvale's staff, and he said he would look into it. Nothing was done. Since the shoes have come down a member of the Sunnyvale Public Safety department told us "we would have gotten them down for you" if we had asked. The fact is that Sunnyvale DPS cars passed under those shoes everyday for several years, and nothing was done.

The fact is that Sunnyvale DPS cars passed under those shoes everyday for several years, and nothing was done. Sometimes, .as the old saying goes, if you want something done right you have to do it yourself

Mike wasn't the only person to respond to the article I wrote last month. Another neighbor reported that a pair of shoes used to be hanging from a wire near the children's playground in Fairwood Park. They are gone now, but he said he would keep watch. Another neighbor wrote an e-mail saying he is a recovering drug addict, and that he would do anything he could to help with a "war on hanging shoes" if it came to that. I asked him to help us look for more shoes, and for more signs of drug activity that "clean and sober" people might miss.

The shoes Mike and I took down have not re-appeared as of yet. It is too early to tell whether they will or not. I hope they won't, but if they do then we'll get them down again. The shoes that were there used to send a bad message to anyone entering Lakewood Village. We need to send another message. We need to let everyone know that we don't like drug dealing in our neighborhood. If we send it loud and clear, it won't be long before that message gets through. ◆



"In Marengo, Iowa, the law says that no more than twenty-seven persons shall participate in a baseball game...In Kenilworth, Illinois, a rooster must step back three hundred feet from any residence if he wishes to crow. Hens that wish to cackle must step two hundred feet back from any residence."

From: The Trenton Pickle Ordinance, by Dick Hyman

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A New Beginning for the LVNA

(Cont. from page 1)

a 2nd Vice President, a Secretary, and a Treasurer. The bylaws spell out various duties for each post. The President runs the meetings, the 1st Vice President oversees the newsletter, the 2nd Vice President chairs the grievance committee, etc. It takes a majority vote of the board for the LVNA to take any official action (which boils down to decisions about spending money). The President has just one vote on the board, just like all of the other officers. On paper, the President has no special authority.

The thing that differentiates the presidency from all other offices in the LVNA is not authority but *responsibility.* In any organization, the buck has to stop somewhere. The other officers of the LVNA can (and do) pass the buck sometimes. The Treasurer can say "I've kept the books up to date, so I've done my job". The Secretary can say "I've kept the meeting minutes, so I've done my job". Someone has to say "There is a job that needs doing, and no one else is stepping up to do it, so I will make sure it gets done." It's the "I will make sure..." part that is the killer. The person who will says that is making an open ended commitment of time and energy to do whatever it takes to get the task accomplished. Other people commit to making an effort. Someone has to commit to delivering results.



EYEBALL TO EYEBALL

Where can that kind of "open ended" commitment lead? Sometimes it leads to "eyeball to eyeball" confrontations for the sake of the neighborhood.

Back in the early 1990s there was an LVNA President named Jessica Lee. During her term the LVNA began the famous "war on graffiti" that was plaguing Lakewood Village. One of the anti-graffiti volunteers was a grandfather named Gene Goldsmith. He fitted out a bicycle with paint, brushes, cleansers and other tools needed to remove tags. He would ride around the neighborhood every morning looking for fresh tagging and either clean it off or paint it over.

One morning he was stopped by the Sunnyvale Department of Public Safety. He was painting over graffiti on the Lakewood Park building. The Public Safety officers said it was just as illegal for him to put paint on the public building as it was for the graffiti artists to do so. He protested and things got a little testy. Gene called Jessica, and she dropped everything to come and help. When she got there she pulled herself up to her full "5 foot nothing" height, stared the public safety officer in the eye and said "If you arrest Gene you'll have to arrest me too!" The officer backed down.

DOING WHAT IT TAKES

Sometimes that "open ended commitment" means going above and beyond the call of duty when others take a walk.

The person who was President before me in the 1990s was a man named Craig Crawford. He became LVNA President just after a very divisive controversy nearly split the LVNA in two. The former President had quit in a huff after he called the Santa Clara city council a "bunch of clowns" and was surprised to find that many of his neighbors felt it was inappropriate for him to do so. Some of the board members left with him. Craig came in to try to pick up the pieces.

How did Craig deal with the situation? He took the phrase "the buck stops here" to heart. He single-handedly organized *every LVNA event* that year – Dumpster Day, the picnic, the parade, and the lighting contest. He organized and coordinated *every LVNA meeting.* To this day, Craig holds the record for personal commitment to the success of the LVNA. The organization I took over in 1996 was there because of Craig. We went on to have many years of success and prosperity because of Craig's self sacrifice.

By the way, the year Craig spent as LVNA President should have been enough for anyone. (*cont. on page 7)*

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A Special Valentine Day Dinner

By Phyllis Fowler

In honor of Valentine's Day, I thought I would share with everybody one of my favorite recipes. Fred and I took a cooking class from a Cordon Blue trained chef called "Cooking With Friends." The group was split in teams and each team prepared a different course. Fred and I were assigned the entrée. We enjoyed the salmon so much, we have made several times. I found that I can make up the salmon packets the night before and then just pop them in the oven. This had made it one of my favorites to serve for dinner parties! If you have too many packets left, don't worry, go ahead and cook them. The next day have them for lunch. Just pop them in the microwave for 2 minutes and voila!

Salmon in Parchment

Fish filets, such as salmon, snapper, cod, and halibut
Cherry tomatoes
Large mushrooms, sliced
Zucchini or summer squash, sliced
Asparagus tips, blanched
Baby carrots, blanched
Shallots, or scallions, minced
Dry white wine
Butter
Salt and peeper
Sprigs of fresh herbs such as basil, tarragon or dill

For each person, you will need a large piece of cooking parchment or foil. The number of filets and amount of vegetables you will need will depend on the number of people you are serving. A nice assortment of colorful vegetables is best.



Fold the piece of parchment in half and butter the bottom half. On it, place some minced shallots or scallions, and place the fish on top. Gather the vegetables of choice and place them on top of the filet. Sprinkle with some dry white wine, dot with butter then salt and pepper, and then finish with a sprig of fresh herb. Fold the paper over and cut so that there is a 1" margin around the fish. Crimp the edges so that there are no air holes.

Tem minutes before you are ready to serve the fish, place them on a baking sheet in a preheated 450 degree oven for 10 minutes, or until the fish goes from translucent to just opaque. Serve immediately on individual plates in the paper. Serve with the citrus balsamic vinaigrette.

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¾ cup fresh orange juice
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2 Tbs. minced onion
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2 Tbs finely minced orange zest
1/8 tps Kosher salt
Freshly cracked pepper

Combine all ingredients in a glass jar, cover tightly and shake vigorously. Set aside. When ready to serve, heat through for a few seconds over high heat and spoon over salmon.

(editor, I have also used this vinaigrette on a salad or as a marinade for chicken. Magnificent!)

As a child my family's menu consisted of two choices: Take it or Leave it!

-Buddy Hackett

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The Origins of St. Valentine's Day

by Phyllis Fowler

February 14 is known as the day we celebrate love. The story of Valentine's Day began during the Roman Empire, which held a festival every February in honor of the God of Fertility. During this time young men would choose their wife. Emperor Claudius changed all of that. Fearing that men would refuse their duty to fight because they would not want to leave their wives behind, he outlawed all marriages. Young couples still fell in love and wished to marry. They went to Catholic Bishop Valentine, he began to secretly marry couples. When Claudius found out, he had Valentine arrested and ordered put to death. While waiting in jail, Valentine began exchanging letters with the jailer's daughter and fell in love with her. The day he was to be beheaded, he wrote her one last note, signed "From Your Valentine'

In 496 A.D. Pope Gelasius outlawed the pagan Festival, knowing its popularity, he replaced it with something more 'appropriate' to honor the martyr St. Valentine. In 1969 the church removed St. Valentine's Day from its 'official' holidays. However, it is still widely celebrated today.

Valentine's Day is perhaps best known for its cards which have been around in one form or another for hundreds of years In the early 1870's a 19-year-old American woman, Esther Howland, started out with three friends and her brother. In assembly line fashion began producing hand-crafted cards which were shipped around the country. By the end of the decade she was making over 100,000$ a year.

Besides giving cards, candy and kisses there are some other interesting Valentine's Day customs. For instance, in England children take to the street, singing songs and passing out cards. In Denmark people give pressed white flowers as a sign of their affection. In the 1700's, English women would write the names of men on small pieces of paper and then roll the paper up inside little balls of clay. They threw the balls into the water and the first paper that popped to the surface was the one with the name of the woman's true love. In the Middle Ages men would pull a woman's name out of a bowl. This would be the man's Valentine. To show his devotion, the man would wear the paper containing the woman's name on his sleeve for a week. This soon became known as '*wearing your heart on your sleeve'*. So go out, find your Valentine and wear your heart on your sleeve! ◆

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A New Beginning for the LVNA

(Cont. from page 4)

Nevertheless, a few years ago when no one else was stepping up, Craig took on the job a *second time* and served another term. One reason I chose to "come out of retirement" and serve again myself, was because of the example that Craig Crawford set for me.

SKILL SETS

What kinds of skills are necessary to be President of the LVNA? That answer is hard to pin down. It varies, because everyone who has held the post brings a different set of skills to the job.

It doesn't hurt to be a good and/or confident writer. One way we keep in touch with each other is through the newsletter you are reading. I'm lucky enough to be able to write fairly well, and so I find I'm comfortable expressing myself in these pages. If there is a problem or issue in Lakewood Village, I tend to write about it. That doesn't mean that writing is the only way to communicate. Other Presidents have used the monthly meetings to accomplish the same kinds of things by speaking rather than writing. Still others have used the telephone. Being able to communicate is very important in this job, but the way the communication is done can vary.



Another important skill or characteristic is to have a "positive" personality. You have to be the kind of person who doesn't just see the glass as half full rather than half empty, you have to be the kind of person who sees a glass with just a few drops of water in it and says "wow! That's GREAT! It isn't bone dry!"

The LVNA is an organization that is powered by volunteers, and volunteers will only sacrifice their time and energy for the gratification of feeling they've been successful in helping a good cause. Negative attitudes and negative messages can kill those feelings, and without those feelings the LVNA will have no volunteers.

We're very blessed this year to have had more than 60 people to participate in at least one LVNA activity. Those people deserve to feel good about what they have done. The LVNA President has to be the head cheerleader for all of those people, and praise every accomplishment, no matter how small.

PERSONAL REWARDS

So what can someone like you get out of being President of the Lakewood Village Neighborhood Association? That depends on what you want to get out of it.

Some Presidents go on to other areas of public service. Jessica Lee went on to become President of the Sunnyvale School District Board of Trustees. LVNA President Vicki Piazza became chair of the Sunnyvale Planning Commission. And some joker named Fred Fowler ended up being Mayor of Sunnyvale.

Other Presidents go back to more "normal" lives. LVNA President Rick Flovin opened a chain of medical clinics with his wife Rena. LVNA President Michael Jenisse got married and moved to St. Louis. LVNA President Craig Crawford and his wife Leah retired and moved to Alaska.

What you get out of it is what you put into it.

What I got out of it was a lack of fear of those "open ended commitments". I'm not afraid of them anymore. I'm willing to make them because I took the risk and found it was a risk I could manage. Part of the reason I've been successful in public service, (as mayor) and in the private sector (as Vice President and CIO of a company in Morgan Hill) is because of the people who work at those levels are the ones who can deal with those kinds of risks. It is fair to say that I wouldn't be where I am today without my stint as President of the LVNA..

ALL IT TAKES IS...

So what does it take? All it takes is that you *care.* All it takes is that the success or failure of the LVNA makes a difference to you personally.

In March of 2009 there was no-one elected President of the LVNA. Nine months later, I stepped in because the LVNA parade was about to be canceled. I'm convinced that if the parade had been canceled then Dumpster Day, the picnic, the monthly meeting and all of the other LVNA activities would have soon followed the parade into oblivion.

If no one steps forward this time there may be no LVNA before long. We're still pretty close to the edge right now. We may still go over the cliff.

Will you let that happen? Do you care? ◆

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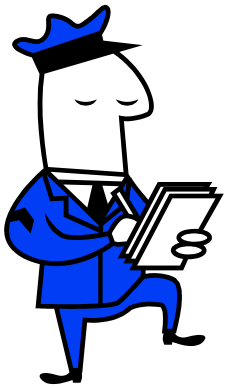
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**********COUPON! **********

California Traffic Fines Have Gone Up!



By Phyllis Fowler

With the change of the new year, comes new laws and an increase in the penalties for disobeying the law. A new law sponsored by State Senator Joe Simitian, makes texting while driving illegal and the fine starts at **$80**. All I can say is "Thank you Joe," too many accidents have been caused by idiots reading or sending text messages! Please keep your eye on the road not your cell phone! Driving while using a wireless phone that is not hands-free is now also up to **$80.** If you have any young drivers at home, remind them to drive not text or talk.

If you move, make sure you report it to the DMV within 10 days or you can be fined **$154** for your driver's license and **$114** for your car registration. When you come to a stop sign, come to a complete stop. Don't roll on through or else it will cost you **$154**

The price for running a **red light** has gone up to a whopping **$400.00** Passing a school bus with flashing red signals is not safe for our children. Now it will now cost those rude drivers **$600**. (*maybe they will pay attention to their pocketbooks!*) Speaking of children, remember to use the passenger child restraints or you could be fined a minimum of **$400**!

If you are tempted to park in a **Handicap parking space**, even for "a few minutes", DON"T. The first offense will cost you **$1,000** and the second time you are caught the fine **doubles**! You will pay **$1,000** for parking in a bus loading area as well. Keep in mind that these amounts I am quoting are set by the state and the cost can vary county by county. In other words, think of this as the minimum due! So drive safely and keep your money in your own pocket.◆

¿

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